

QUEER QUEST Kabir Maan and Sirat Taneja in a still from *Aman*; inset, director Rahul Roye

to keep the baby, and continued with his transition. "When I came across their story, I realised that there are many such stories but it's just that they never get told in our films," Roye tells INDIA TODAY.

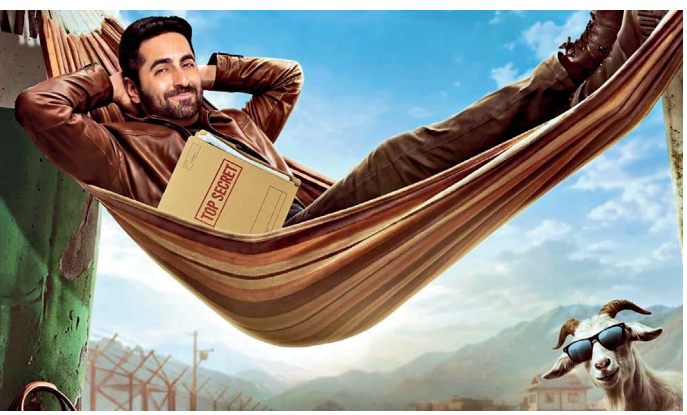
Shot in Hindi and Bengali, the 16-minute short begins with that seeming contradiction: Aman, a trans man played by debut actor Kabir Maan, discovers he is pregnant on the eve of his gender-affirming surgery. "I thought that if I put a trans man at the centre of a pregnancy, I could explore how fragile our definitions of gender are, especially since gender is something that is so fluid."

The film's interest in pregnancy is also rooted in the filmmaker's experience growing up non-binary. "I could never see myself in any of the pre-existent, colonial, heteronormative gender binaries." Pregnancy, in particular, offered a way to examine those boundaries because, as per Roye, it continues to be "one of the most gendered experiences".

That tension also allows Roye to explore gender dysphoria on screen without reducing Aman's pregnancy to a crisis of identity. Instead, the film asks what happens when a body that has fought to be recognised as male undergoes an experience so culturally associated with womanhood.

In a way, this question extends to the film's casting. In a departure from the convention of trans characters being played by cis actors in Indian cinema, *Aman* casts trans actors in its trans roles. Alongside Maan, the cast includes Sirat Taneja, who previously starred in Deepa Mehta's *I Am Sirat* (2023). ■

— Poulomi Das



▲ **OCT. 9** | *Theatres*

UDTA TEER

Spies have been in fashion for a while now in Bollywood. Now the spoofs are coming. Ayushmann Khurrana stars in this spy comedy alongside Sara Ali Khan, Gulshan Grover, Ram Kapoor, Rahul Bose et al.

▼ **SEPT. 25** | *JioHotstar*

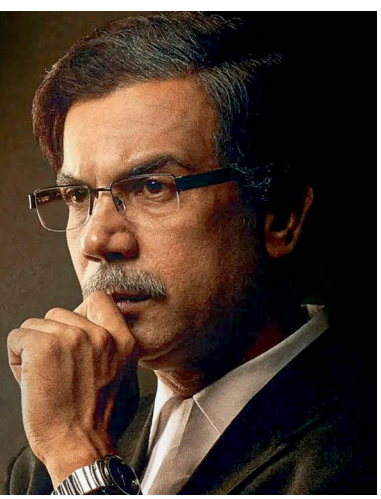
Hunkaar: the Roar



Raghubir Yadav, known for his everyman roles, is cast against type as a creepy, all-powerful godman in this series. Fatima Sana Shaikh plays a cop investigating allegations of sexual violence made by a student (Aneet Padda) against the godman. Mohammad Zeeshan Ayyub, Arjun Mathur and Zoya Hussain round up the cast.

▶ **OCT. 16** | *Theatres*

Prahaar: The Untold Story of Ujjwal Nikam



Public prosecutor and now Rajya Sabha MP Ujjwal Nikam gets the biopic treatment. Rajkummar Rao plays him. Nikam is best-known for high-profile cases like the 1993 Bombay blasts and the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks. Popular Marathi actor Lalit Prabhakar plays Ajmal Kasab. Wamiqa Gabbi, Jaideep Ahlawat and Sikandar Kher also star.

— Compiled by Devarsi Ghosh